

Praise as Supremely Excellent Among Gods

Deva Atiśaya Stotra · Toh 1112 · Derge Tengyur

ལྟལས་ཕུལ་དེ་བྱུང་བར་བསྟོད།

Toh 1112 in the Tengyur is a devotional hymn known in Sanskrit as the Deva Atiśaya Stotra and in Tibetan as Lha Las Phul Du Byung Bar Bstod Pa, meaning "Praise as Supremely Excellent Among Gods." It is a stotra, or praise poem, that extols the Buddha by contrasting his qualities with those of the great Hindu deities Viṣṇu, Brahmā, and Śiva, arguing through reasoned comparison that the Buddha alone — having attained perfect peace — is truly worthy of worship. The text systematically examines the conduct, powers, and nature of these divine figures to demonstrate the Buddha's unsurpassed excellence, making it both a work of devotional literature and a form of philosophical polemic. As Toh 1112 in the Tengyur, it belongs to the collection of Indian scholarly and literary works preserved in the Tibetan Buddhist canon, falling within the category of hymns and praises composed in the classical Sanskrit stotra tradition.

In Sanskrit: Deva Atiśaya Stotra. In Tibetan: Praise as Supremely Excellent Among Gods.

Homage to all the Tathāgatas.

The Blessed One, the Sugata, is not perceived directly — he is not Viṣṇu. Brahmā is not he, nor is the Great God (Śiva) seen to be he. Hearing of their forms, powers, conduct, and intentions, let one examine which has merit and which does not.

Viṣṇu strives to bear a mighty army, weapons, and a club;
the Great God wears garlands fashioned from human skulls.
If the Buddha alone has reached the pinnacle of perfect peace,
then judge between one who is at peace and one who is not — which deserves
worship?

Viṣṇu has destroyed the families of the Daityas and others hard to battle;
the Great God is famed to have demolished the triple city.
Śoṣaṇa too struck cranes with a short lance and slew them.
The Buddha alone acts as physician to all beings —
consider these and judge.

"I will harm this one, protect this one, slay this one" — such is the established doctrine of the highest among gods.

But the Buddha has neither enemy nor friend;
he benefits all with certainty, with excellence, with manifest elevation.

Viṣṇu alone gives rise to faults such as attachment and the rest;
the conduct of the Great God is like that of a madman.
Since the Tathāgata dispels every fault without exception,
consider who deserves to be called the Great Teacher.

One who, without compassion, strives to harm others,
and one to whom beings have gone for refuge —
one who harbors attachment, and one who is completely free of attachment —
reflect carefully and say which of these is worthy of worship here.

Śakra (Indra, the king of the gods) bears the vajra and is strong; he carries a
winnowing fan; Viṣṇu bears the discus as his weapon;
Śoṣaṇa holds a short lance; the Great God bears the three-pointed weapon; he
abides in charnel grounds.

These are childish, without heartfelt compassion, bearing various weapons,
threatened by fear and suffering.

Always striving to destroy living beings — what wise person would bow to such
a one?

One who does not carry the trident, who when affectionate has no wife
present,
who does not bear the discus or the fierce short lance or the winnowing fan,
who is freed from afflictions, skilled, and strives to benefit others —
that sage, the refuge of the world, to him alone do I here go for refuge.

The Great God is ruled by attachment, has cast off shame, and takes a
low-born woman.

Viṣṇu is exceedingly fierce, and his deeds are wasted — Śoṣaṇa even slays his
own kin.

The one difficult to appease is wrathful and kills the buffalo; the Mātṛkās eat
human flesh and fat.

These misleading companions, for all their great power and ten strengths,
have not a single small fault that is absent.

The Blessed One is not my kinsman, nor are these other non-Buddhists my
enemies.

Their conduct too I have not seen become directly manifest.

Yet from words and deeds, hearing the distinctions between each of them,

because the qualities of the Buddha are supremely excellent, out of faith I take him as my refuge.

The Sugata is not my father, nor are these other non-Buddhists my enemies. The Tathāgata has not given me wealth, nor has he taken anything — not food or the like.

Yet this Buddha, this Blessed One, alone acts as physician to all beings — so it is proclaimed.

He who is stainless, who dispels all stain — in him I have faith.

He who always delights in benefit, who continuously works for the welfare of beings;

he who makes comfortable the many beings tormented by suffering;

he who clearly perceives all knowable things as though in the palm of his hand —

in that peerless sage, whose causes are complete, I have arisen sincere and heartfelt faith.

Whether from the depths of the heart, however joyfully,

or through doubt, or merely for the sake of others —

whoever pays homage to that sage, the moon-like sovereign of the able ones, will obtain the supreme joy of the gods.

Long ago, when Viṣṇu had obtained mastery over the birth, aging, sickness, and death of the world —

— with extraordinary wisdom and compassionate diligence, he caused the Śākya lineage to flourish,

and in the realm of Gautama, born upon this earth,

it is heard and known that he became a buddha.

Yet ordinary beings, through the stupidity and confusion of their afflictions, do not seek the Teacher's benefit — how strange!

When, through attachment and aversion, they rob jewel-wealth from the homes of the asuras,

and when, through minds deluded by desire, they act with treachery and seize lands —

at that very time, while Viṣṇu himself remains unliberated,

foolish common people still offer worship and bow down to him.

Though the buddha is assuredly and completely liberated,

the great majority of beings, in their confusion, do not pay homage to him.

This earth, weighed down with the heavy burden of a girdle woven from the four oceans,
sits like something enormously heavy —
and even though Viṣṇu sustains it, in that moment of great exertion he abides in suffering.

By offering even a particle of dust to the Sage,
a king, through sorrowless joy, will obtain an earth
adorned throughout by the cool cool rays of the lunar orb.

I hold to no faction of the buddha's own,
nor do I bear hatred toward the yellow-robe and grey-robe traditions and the like.

Whatever words are endowed with reason,
those alone I hold up and proclaim.

In this way, whoever it may be — if one truly possesses omniscience
and follows the great tradition of benefiting beings in a singular way —
having sought such a person out with the eye of subtle discernment,
one should follow that teacher. What use, for the wise, is any other?

For one in whom all faults are absent
and all virtues are present,
even Brahmā, Viṣṇu, and the Great God (Śiva) —
they too would be my Teacher.

One in whom no faults are found,
who possesses boundless virtues,
who is omniscient and compassionate —
in that one I take refuge.

With eyes as long as the opened, spreading petals of a lotus,
I have thus praised that ocean with a thousand rivers of eulogy.
Whatever little virtue has been created by my words,
may all sentient beings thereby be endowed with happiness.

The Praise Transcending the Gods, composed by the master
Sukhākara-svāmin, is complete.

Translated by the Indian abbot Sarvajñādeva and the translator-monk Rinchen Chok.

Translator's Notes

- The text is the Deva Atiśaya Stotra, a praise of the Buddha as supremely excellent among gods, attributed in the Tibetan canon and likely composed in the Sanskrit tradition of polemic comparison between the Buddha and Hindu deities. The term rendered "Śoṣaṇa" (Tibetan: སྦྲུམ་ཆུ་འཕྲུལ་) is a little-used epithet meaning "the Desiccator" or "Dryer-up," sometimes identified with a form of Śiva or a related deity; I have retained it as a proper name since its precise identification among the Hindu pantheon in this context is contested. The passage ends mid-sentence, indicating that the supplied Tibetan is incomplete and breaks off at the opening of a new narrative comparison.
- The phrase rendered "yellow-robe and grey-robe traditions" refers to Buddhist monks (in ochre or saffron robes) and the grey-robed Jain mendicants respectively; the author is signaling impartiality among Indian religious schools.

The colophon names the text's author as Sukhacara-svāmin, a Sanskrit back-formation from the Tibetan bde byed bdag po, an otherwise little-attested figure; identification with a known author remains uncertain.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.